

solution to this, supporting many IM services, even IRC! Get it at <http://pidgin.im/download/>.

## VirtualBox

A lot of tech enthusiasts/software reviewers need to try out a new OS without actually installing it. VirtualBox is the solution. Downloadable at home or office without paying a cent, you can use it to safely try the new OS, and when done, simply delete the VM. You can decide how much disk and RAM to allocate to the guest OS, and even decide on network access privileges, etc. Get it at <https://www.virtualbox.org/wiki/Downloads>.

## Open Office

Need to do word-processing, spreadsheets, presentations, graphics and databases, but don't want to shell out for proprietary software? Switch to OpenOffice/LibreOffice, which can do it all. It takes some time to get used to the interface, though. It has support for most languages, globally. It also supports .docx and .doc so you can work with those using Microsoft products. Get it from <http://www.openoffice.org/download/index.html>.

## Mozilla Thunderbird

If you need a free alternative to Outlook, look no further. Thunderbird is easy to use, and can also work as an RSS reader. It has a lot of add-ons to simplify daily tasks. Adaptive junk mail filtering helps control spam; the export feature makes shifting mail, settings, contacts, etc, to a new computer a whole lot easier. Get it from <http://www.mozilla.org/en-US/thunderbird/>.

## Deja dup

Back-up is usually a headache for most users, but a necessity to protect valuable data. Deja dup lets you do this without any hassles. The simple interface lets you back up data to a hard drive or to Amazon S3, and also automate it daily, weekly or monthly. Get it at <https://launchpad.net/deja-dup/+download>.

## Code Blocks

This is a very popular cross-platform C/C++ IDE, which supports plug-ins to extend capabilities/features. It can be used to code for ARM, Matlab, OpenGL, AVR, etc (and a few other platforms, but you need to first install the corresponding framework/SDK). Get it from <http://www.codeblocks.org/downloads>.

## Blender

This is an open source 3D creation software available for all major operating systems. It lets you create animated films, visual effects, video games, etc, with a lot of other advanced features. There are many tutorials on its site for a head start. Get it at <http://www.blender.org/download/get-blender/>.

## GNU Image Manipulation Program (GIMP)

The free alternative to Photoshop is usable for photo retouching, image composition, authoring and much more. It can be used as a simple paint program, an expert image editing workshop, and even as a batch-processing system, a mass-production image renderer, an image format converter, etc. Expandable and extensible, you can download plug-ins for almost any task, and use the advanced scripting interface to automate anything from the simplest tasks to the most complex image manipulation procedures. Get it at <http://www.gimp.org/downloads/>.

## 7-zip

This powerful open source archive management tool supports most archive formats like .tar, .rar, .zip, etc. Get it from <http://www.7-zip.org/download.html>.

After using these, you will definitely feel that open source applications are on par with proprietary software, and in some cases, even better! **END** 

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